
48 exercises / instructions

THREE KINDS OF QUESTION

Questions 1-24 test opening recall, 25-36 test plans and defense, and 37-48 compare concrete candidates from the laboratories. These are not all tactical puzzles and do not all have one uniquely best move.

WORK WITHOUT THE ANSWER

Use a board and write your answer. Spend two to five minutes on a recall question and five to ten on a candidate comparison. Name the opponent's threat before choosing your own move.

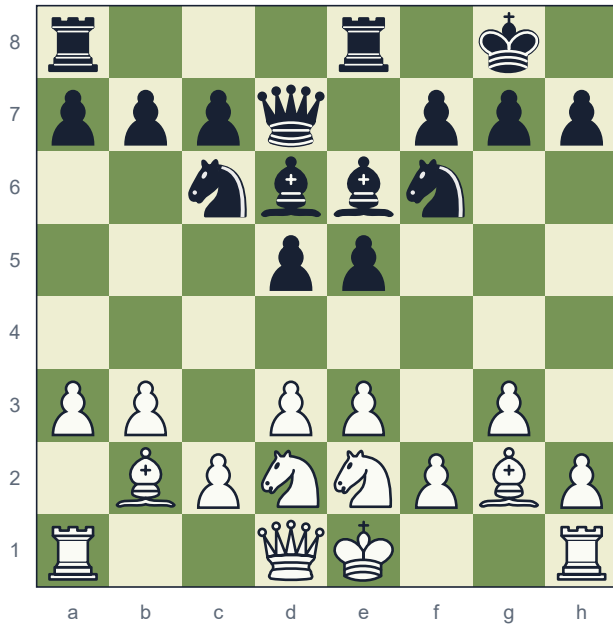
MARKING

Award one point for a legal, relevant choice or plan; one for a clear reason; one for recognizing the opponent's resource; and one for a supporting variation or accurate description of the structure. Maximum: 192. Do not reward memorized notation that you cannot explain.

ANSWERS ARE LATER

The question pages come first, followed by explained answers and sample continuations. In planning questions the sample answer is a guide, not an exhaustive list of reasonable plans.

Exercises 1-2



White to move

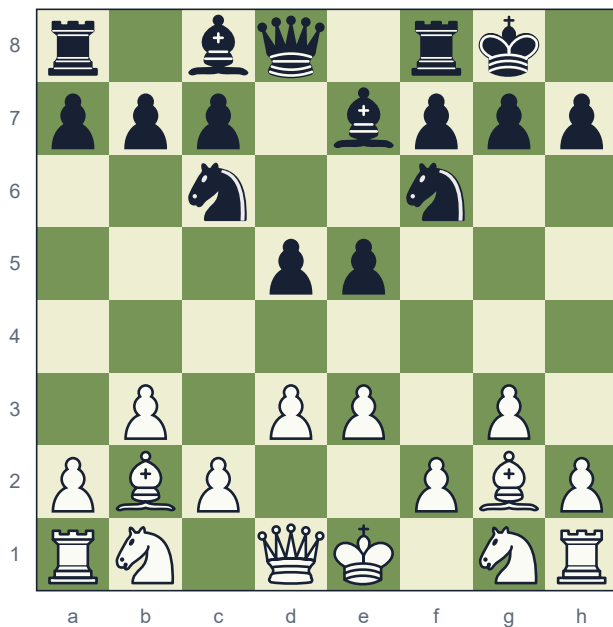
01 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

02 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 3-4



White to move

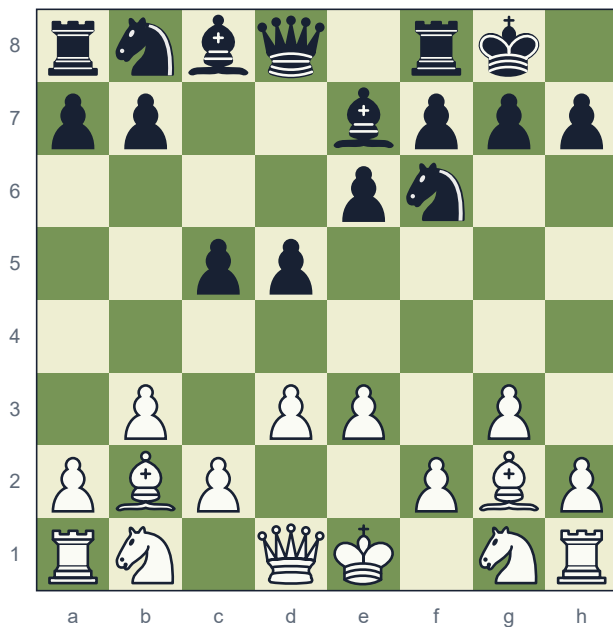
03 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

04 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 5-6



White to move

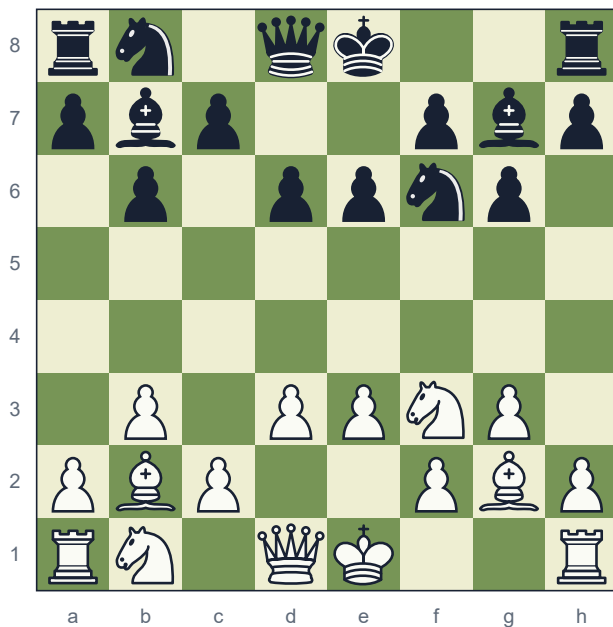
05 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

06 / OPENING RECALL

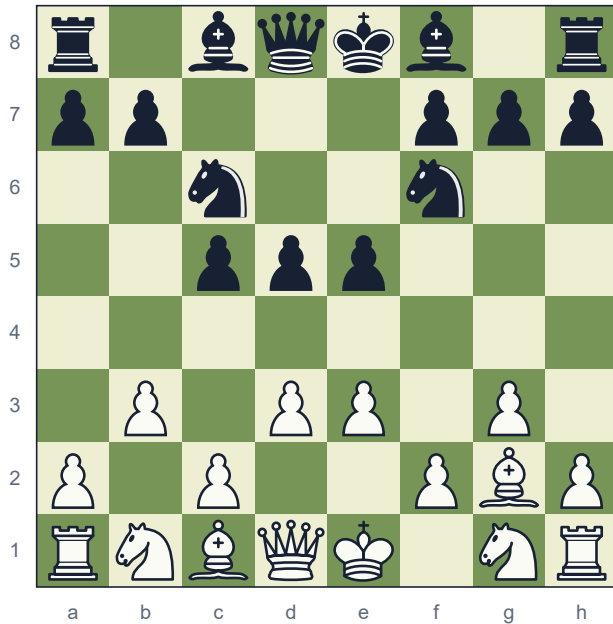
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 7-8



White to move

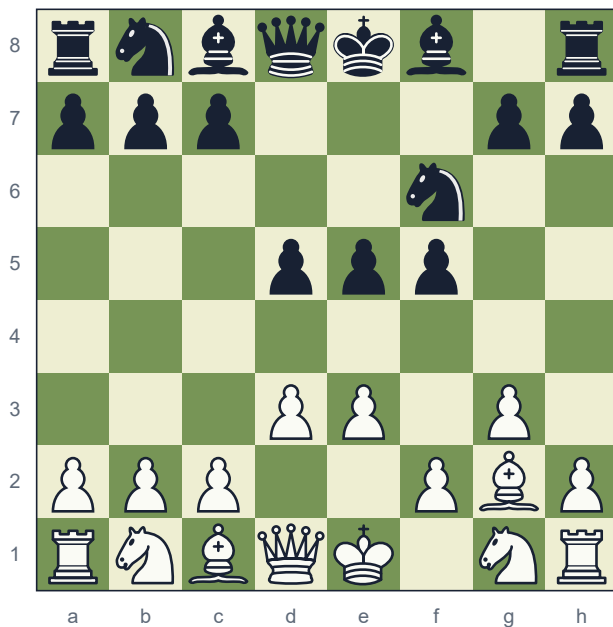
07 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

08 / OPENING RECALL

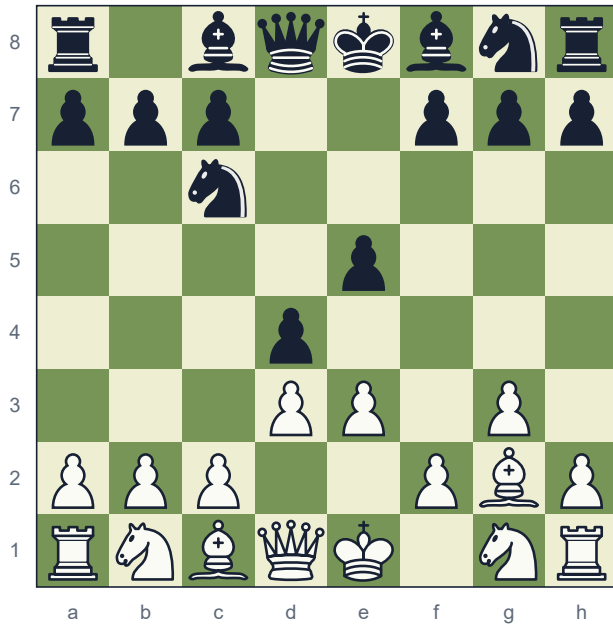
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 9-10



White to move

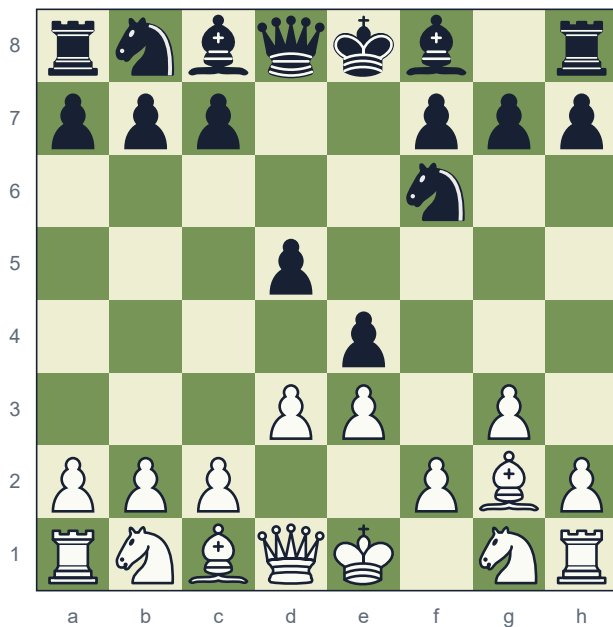
09 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

10 / OPENING RECALL

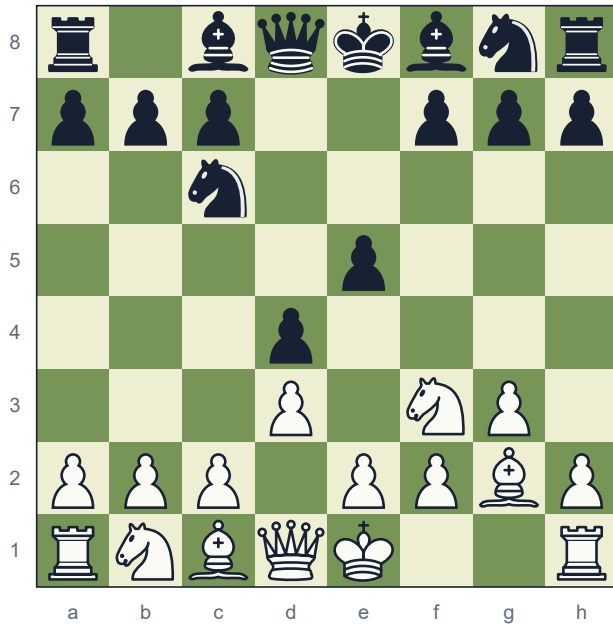
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 11-12



White to move

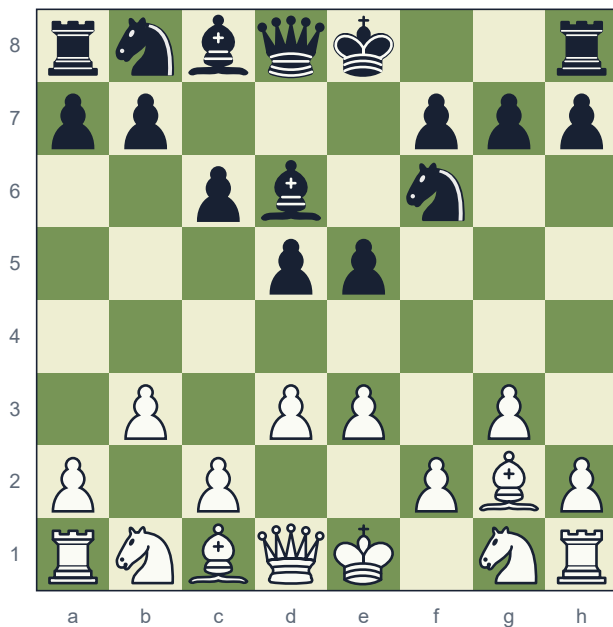
11 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

12 / OPENING RECALL

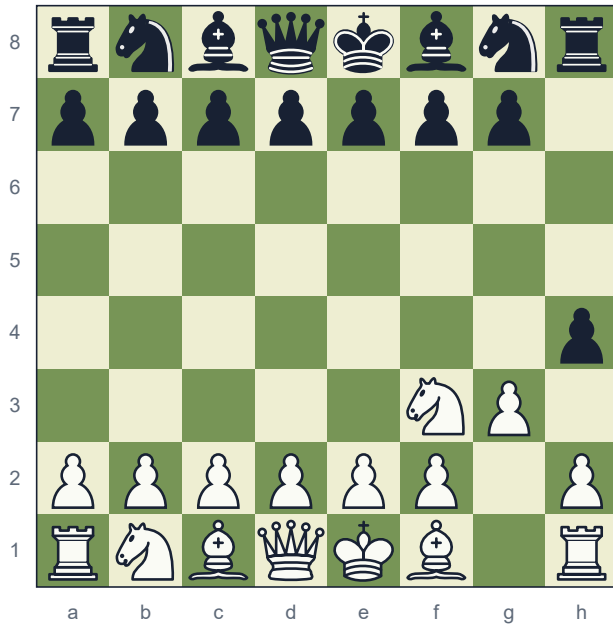
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 13-14



White to move

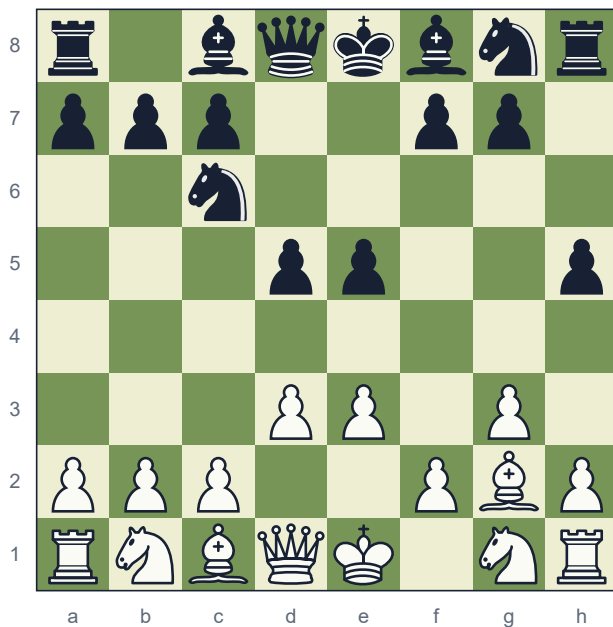
13 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

14 / OPENING RECALL

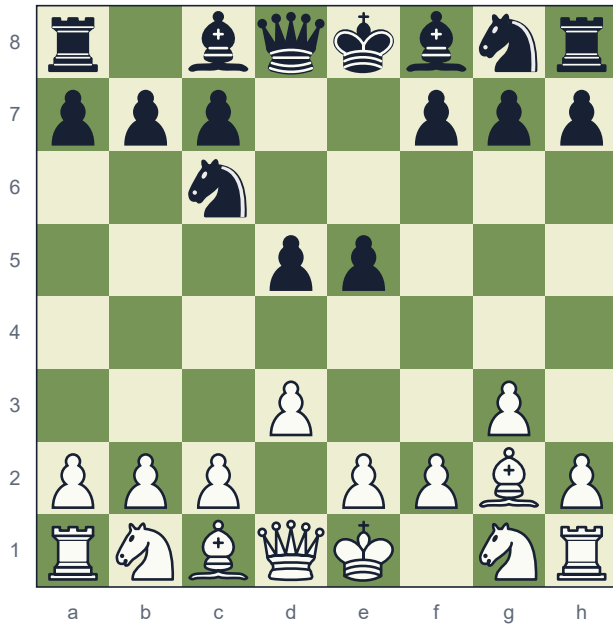
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 15-16



White to move

15 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

16 / OPENING RECALL

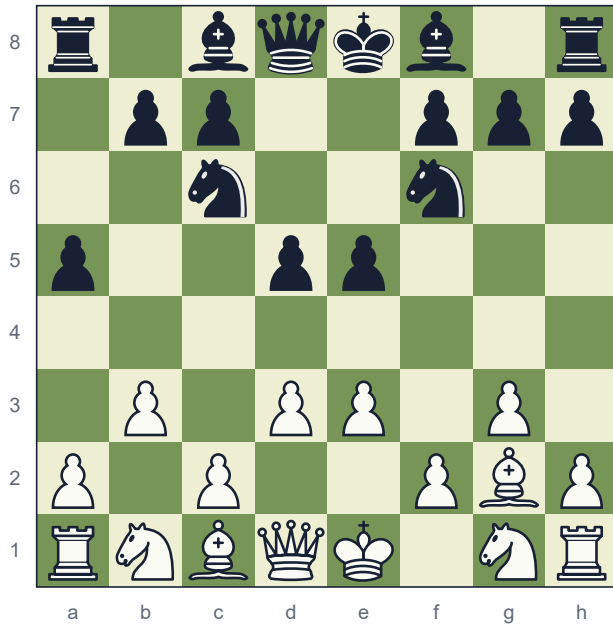
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 17-18



White to move

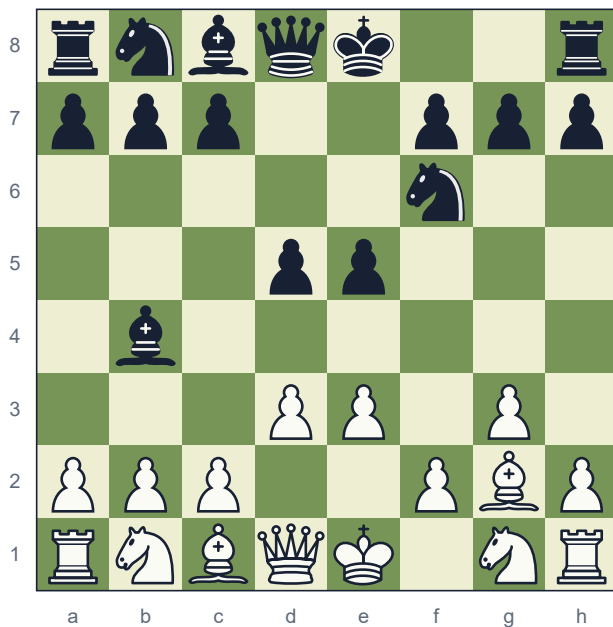
17 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move - in check

18 / OPENING RECALL

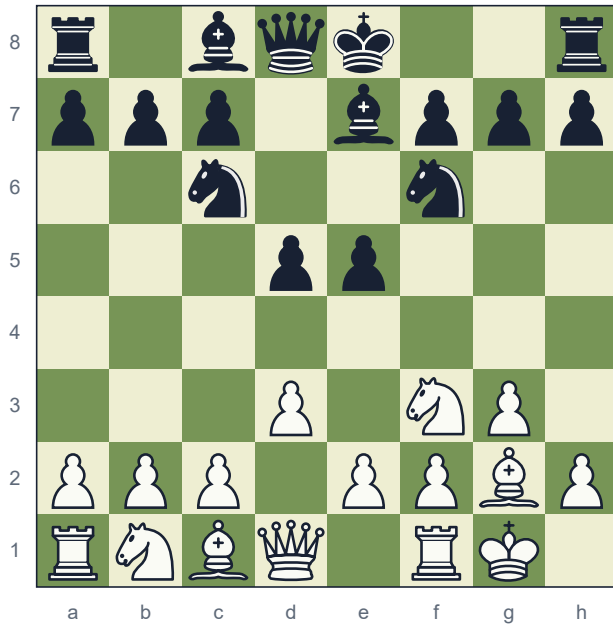
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 19-20



White to move

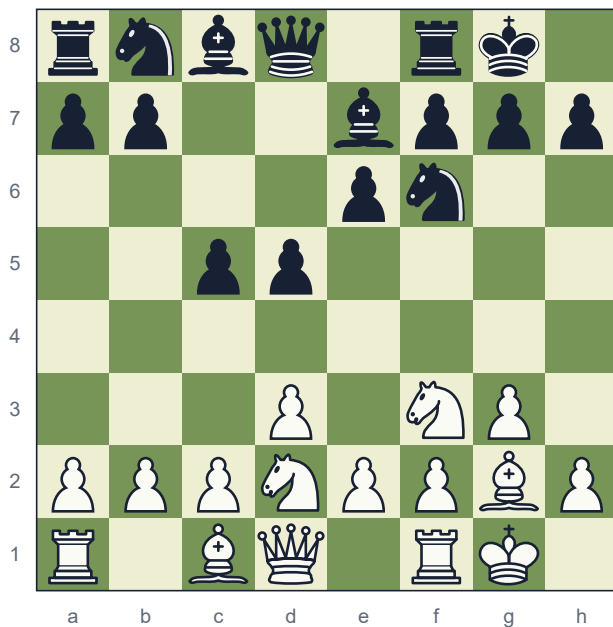
19 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

20 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 21-22



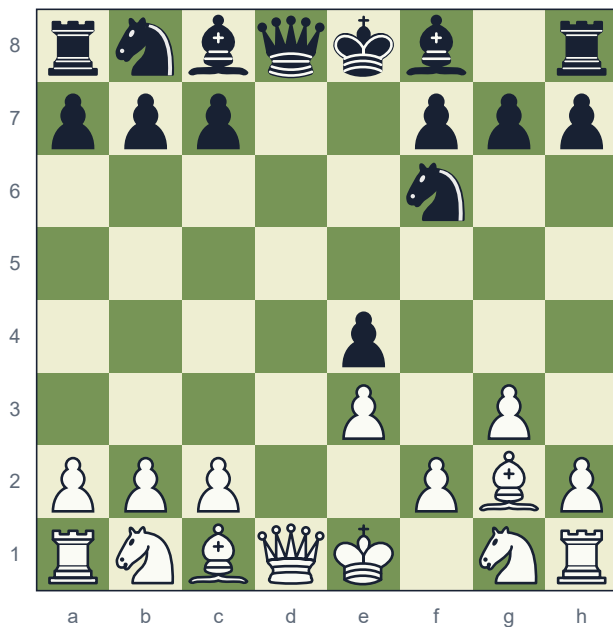
21 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



22 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 23-24



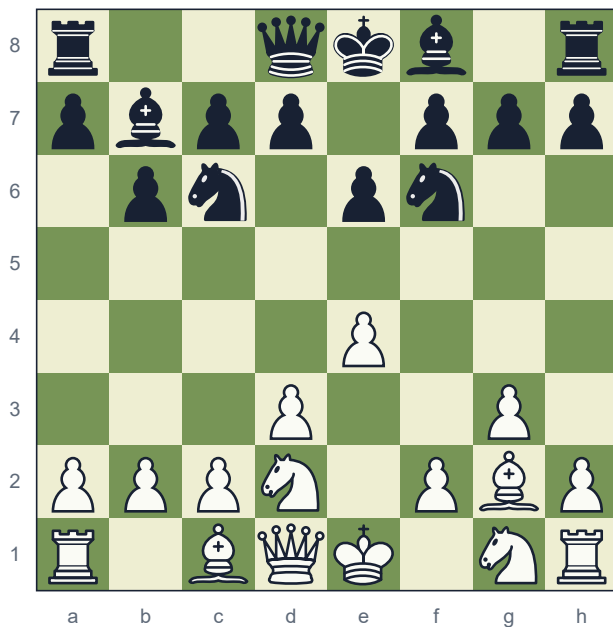
23 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



24 / OPENING RECALL

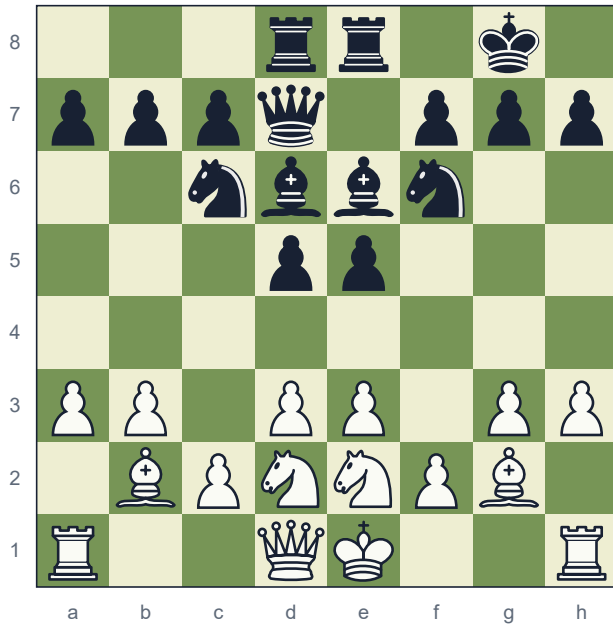
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 25-26



White to move

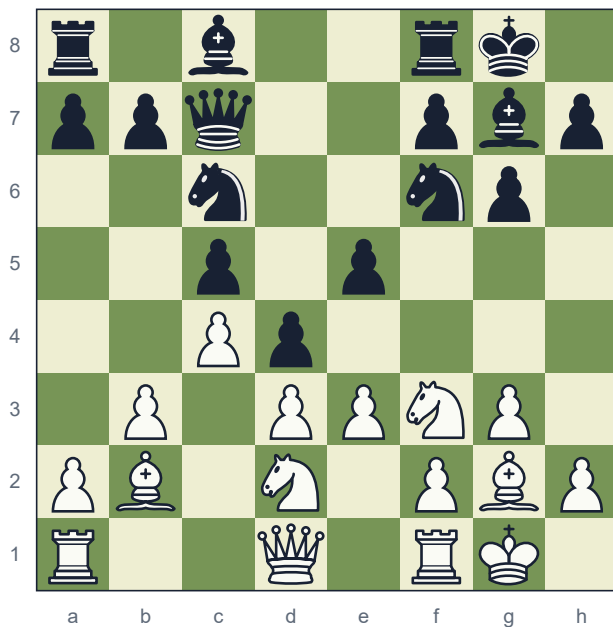
25 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

26 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

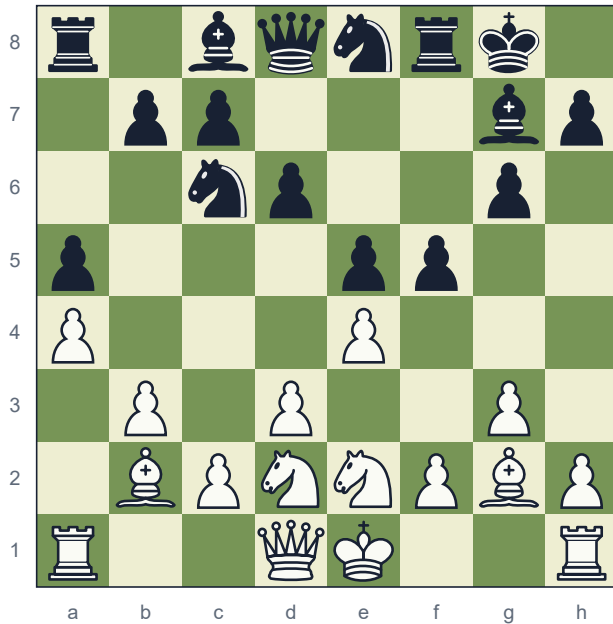
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 27-28



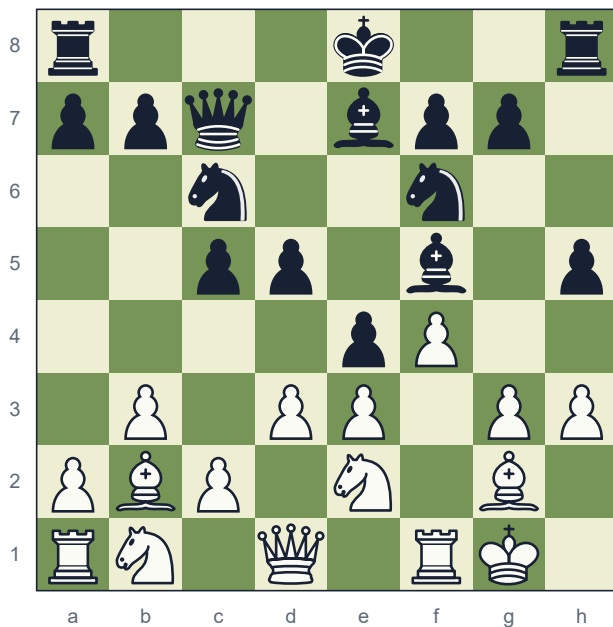
27 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



28 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

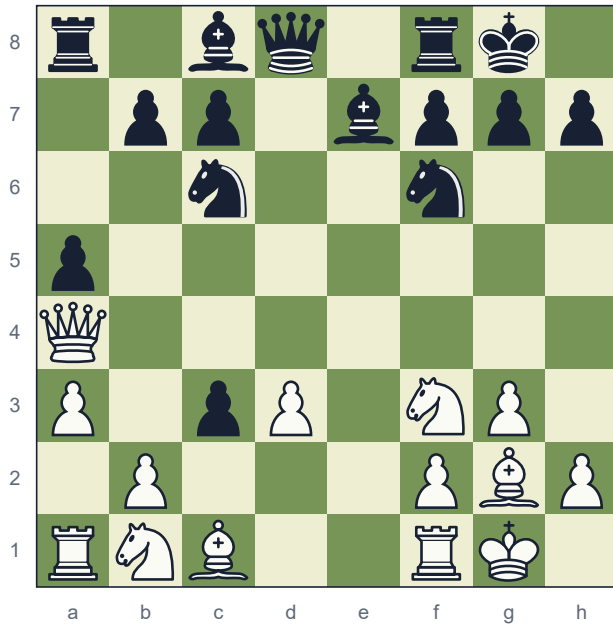
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 29-30



White to move

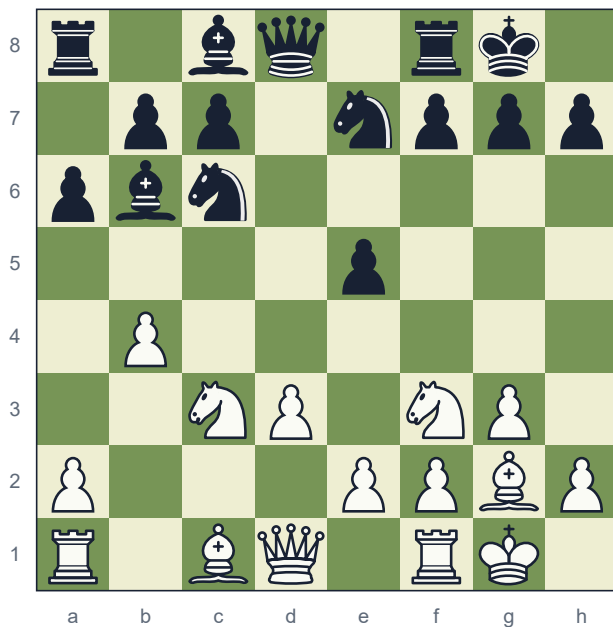
29 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

30 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

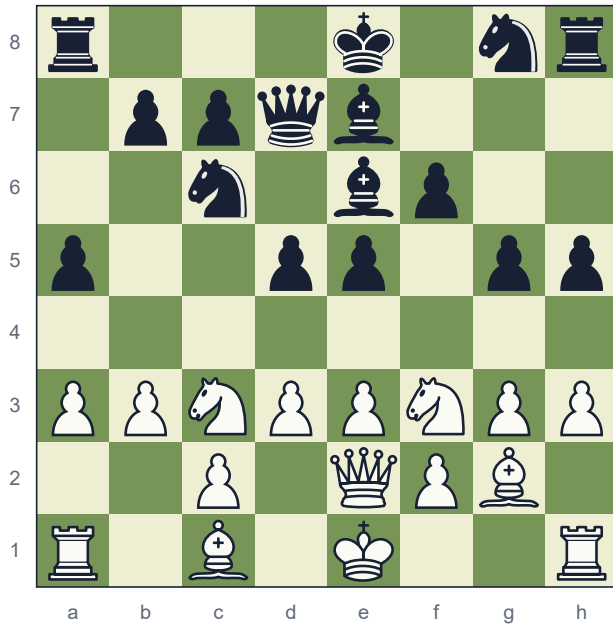
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 31-32



White to move

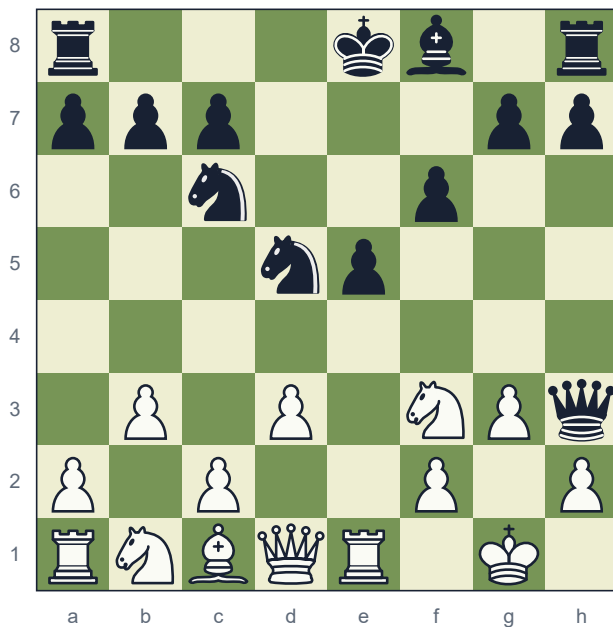
31 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

32 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

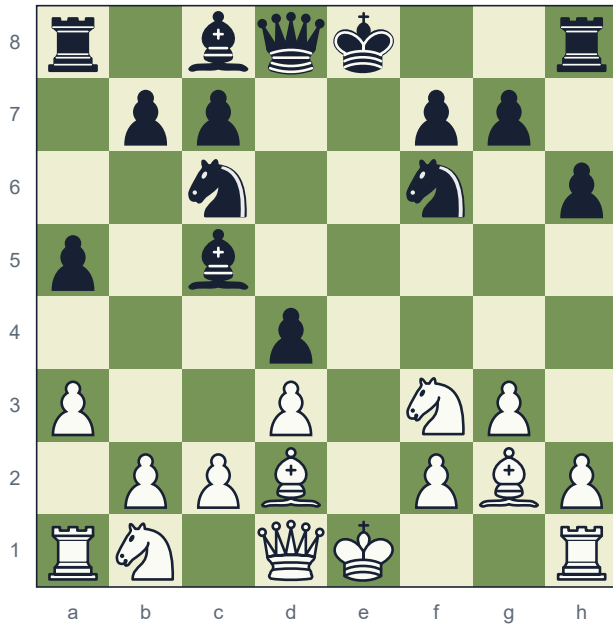
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 33-34



White to move

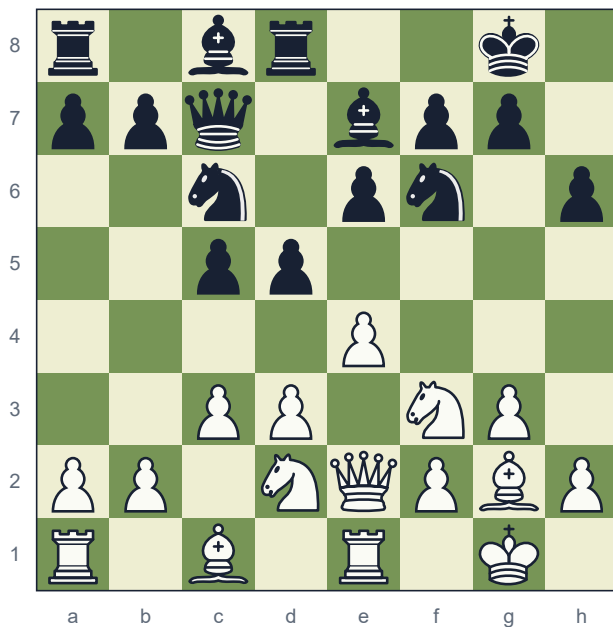
33 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

34 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

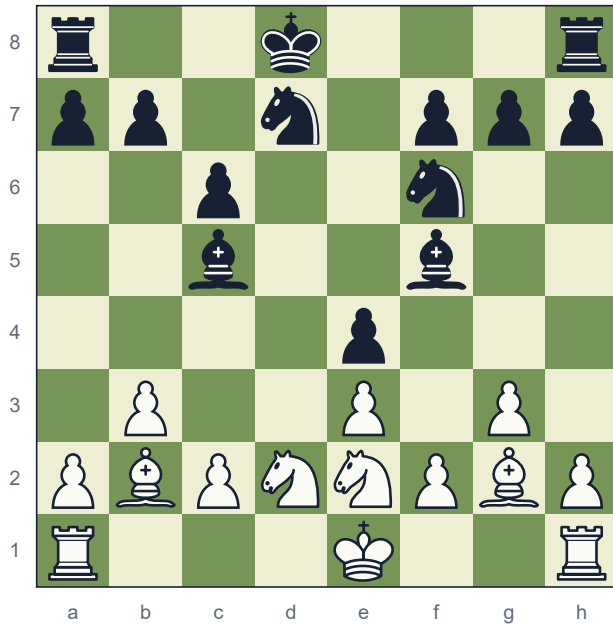
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 35-36



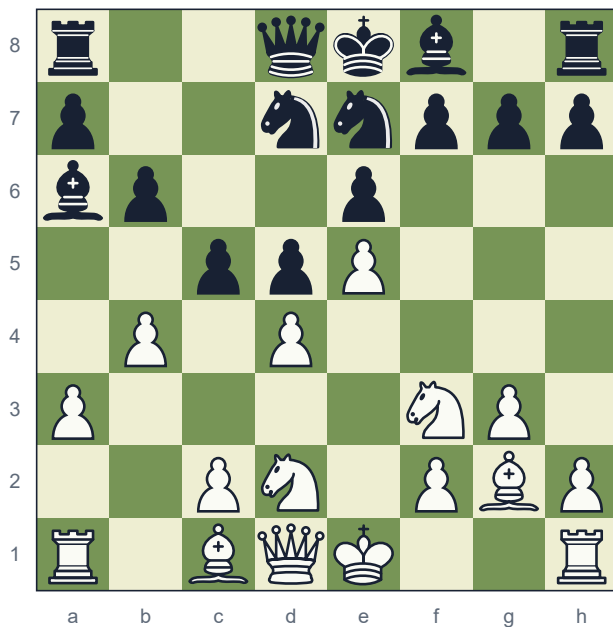
35 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



36 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

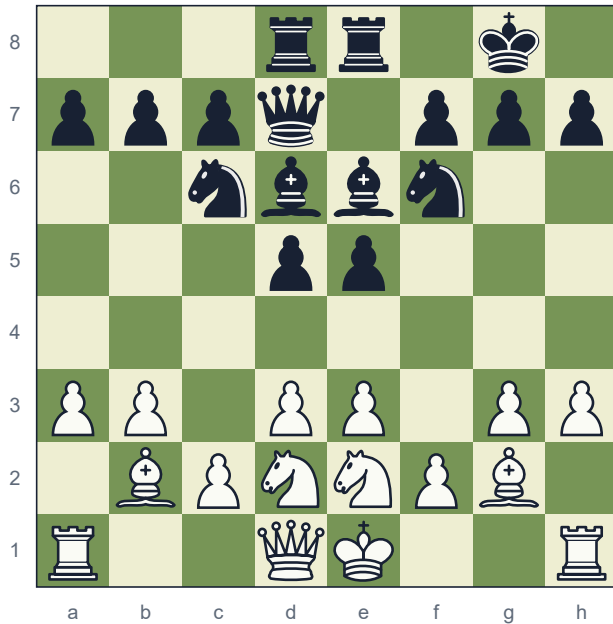
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 37-38



White to move

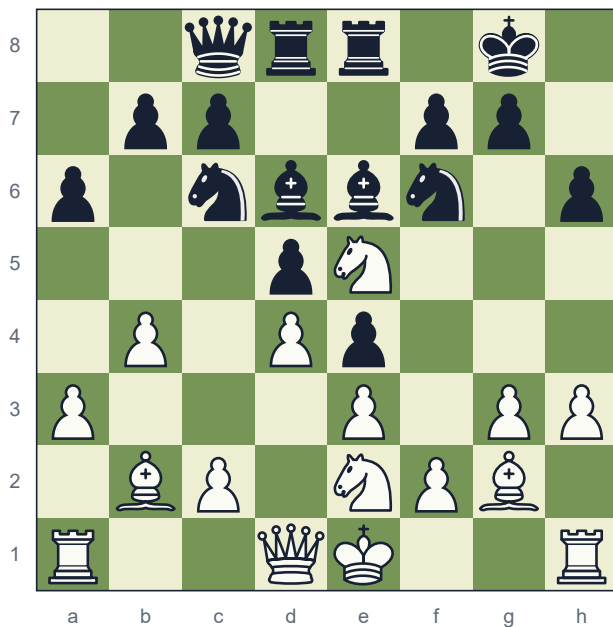
37 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare g4 with Nf3. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

38 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

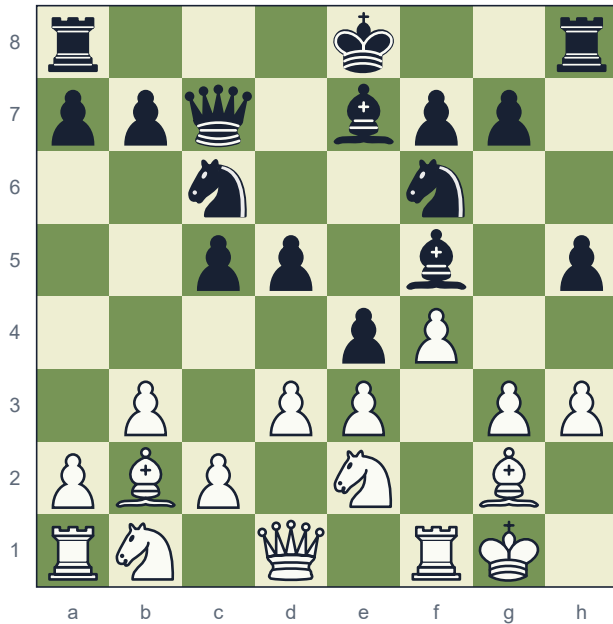
Compare Nxc6 with Nf4. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 39-40



White to move

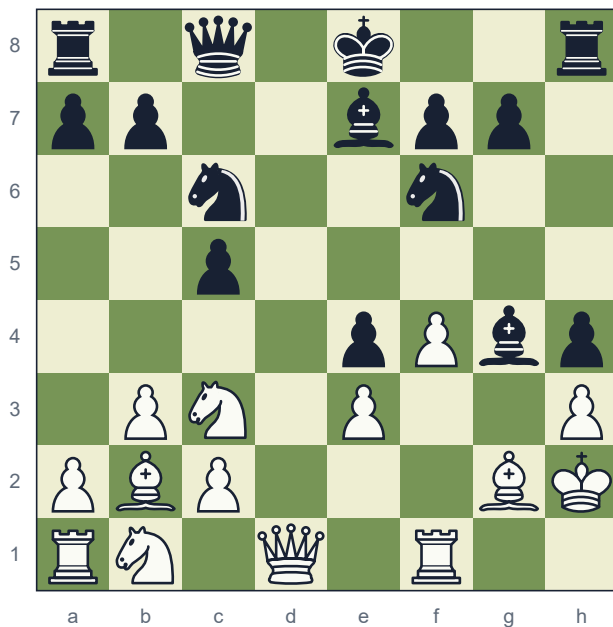
39 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Bxf6 with dxe4. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

40 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

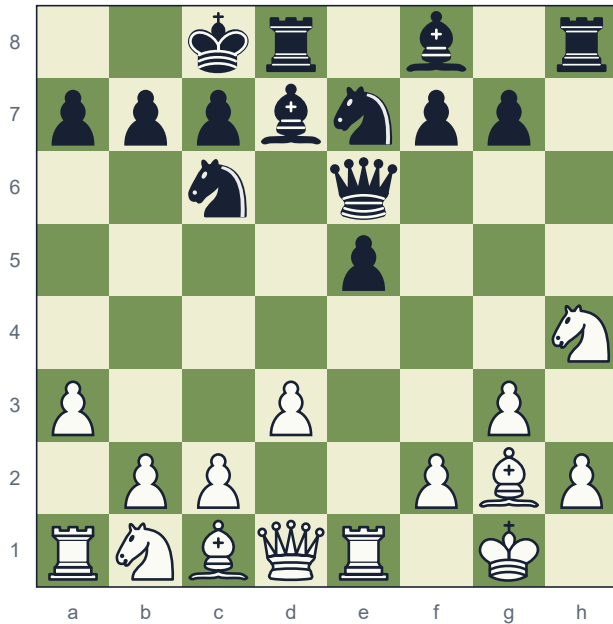
Compare hxc4 with Qd2. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 41-42



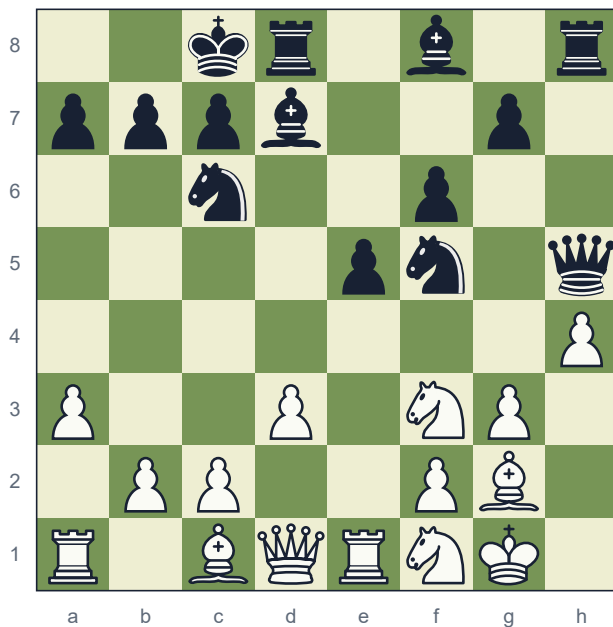
41 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare b4 with Nf3. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



42 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

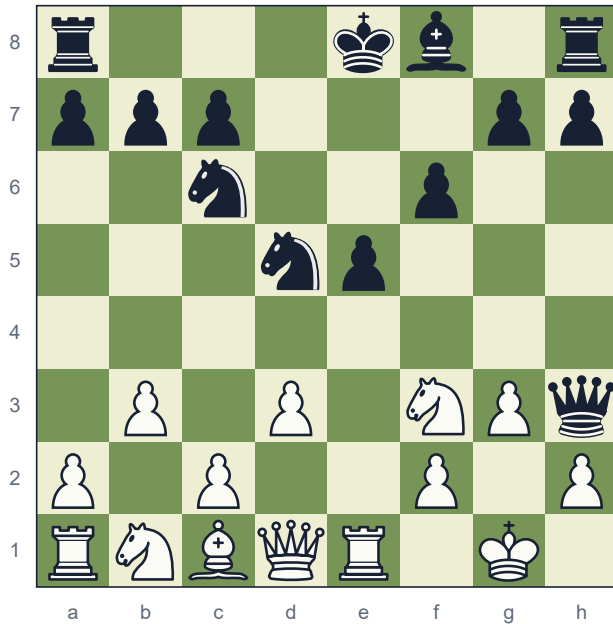
Compare c3 with b4. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 43-44



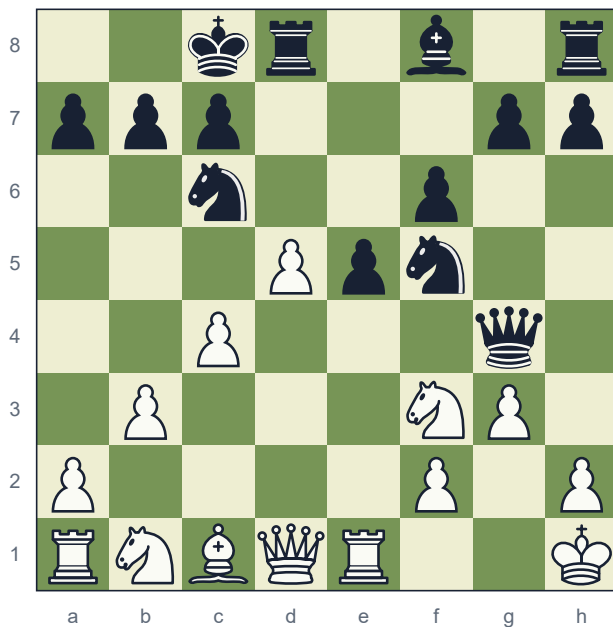
43 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare c4 with d4. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



44 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

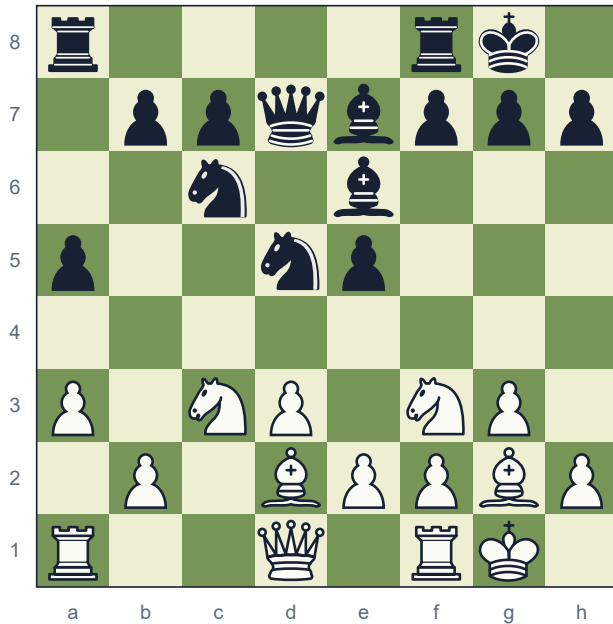
Compare Nfd2 with Nbd2. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 45-46



White to move

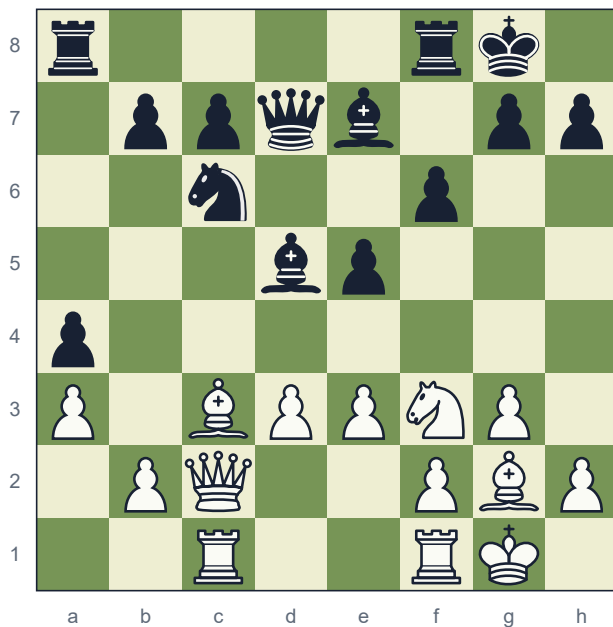
45 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Re1 with Rc1. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

46 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

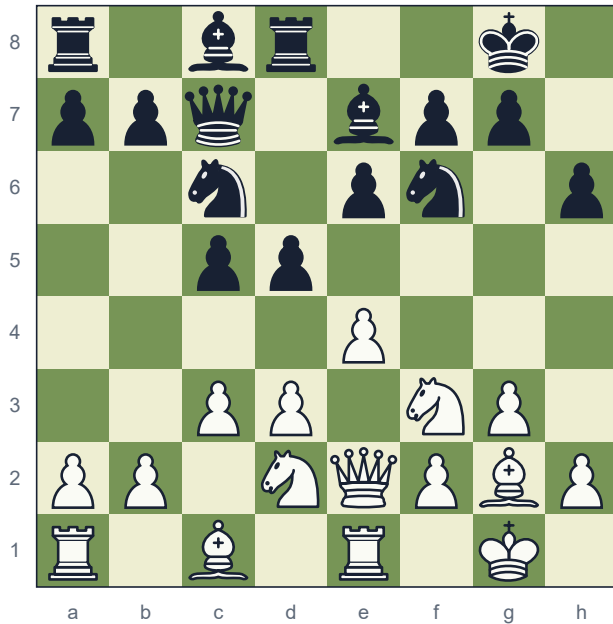
Compare Nh4 with Rfe1. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 47-48



White to move

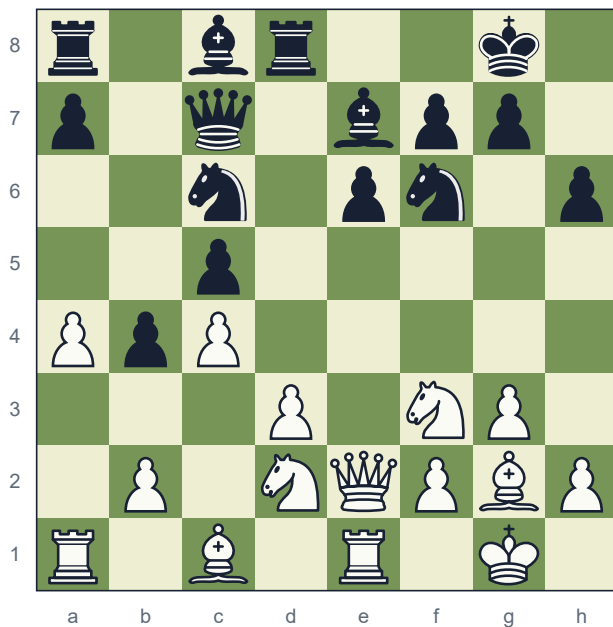
47 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare a4 with a3. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

48 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Nb3 with a5. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Answers 1-2

01 / HW-01

Course move: 10. h3. White reaches the familiar two-rank formation while Black occupies the center. This quiet illustrative route is not a claim that all ten setup moves are best in every position.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

10. h3 Rad8

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black has more space and can prepare ...e4 or ...d4. White's extra tempo has not prevented a central bind.

02 / HW-02

Course move: 7. Nd2. Black develops modestly and keeps the center intact. White preserves flexibility while the bishops watch long diagonals.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7. Nd2 Re8 8. h3 Bd6 9. Ngf3 h6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black may use ...Re8 and ...Bf8 to prepare central expansion. Quiet development can support a serious squeeze.

Answers 3-4

03 / HW-03

Course move: 7. Nd2. Black combines central space with a fianchetto. White's b2 bishop points toward the opposing king side, but central pawns may block its influence.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7. Nd2 Qc7 8. Ngf3 Nc6 9. O-O e5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can advance ...d4 and restrict the b1 knight. The g7 bishop may become stronger than its white counterpart after exchanges.

04 / HW-04

Course move: 7. Nd2. Black has a stable d5-e6 center but has not occupied e5. White has time to prepare a direct central challenge.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7. Nd2 Nc6 8. Ngf3 b5 9. O-O Qc7

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

...Nc6 and ...e5 can gain more space. Do not wait for Black to complete every central ambition before responding.

Answers 5-6

05 / HW-05

Course move: 7. Nd2. Black's d6 pawn supports e5 and keeps the center flexible. White can choose a partial Hippo or a more active King's Indian Attack structure.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7. Nd2 a5 8. a4 Nc6 9. e4 Ne8

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can use ...Nc6 and ...Be6 to develop with central influence. A later ...d5 may seize the initiative if White waits too long.

06 / HW-06

Course move: 8. Nbd2. Both sides restrain the center, but the knights on f3 and f6 block the opposing fianchetto diagonals before b-pawn moves expose the corner rooks. This detail prevents a tactical accident.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

8. Nbd2 Nbd7 9. b4 c5 10. a3 O-O

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Without a blocker on the long diagonal, b3 or ...b6 can expose a corner rook to the enemy bishop. Never build this formation without tracing the diagonal.

Answers 7-8

07 / HW-07

Course move: 6. Bb2. Black establishes c5-d5-e5. White must challenge the center before completing every wing pawn move.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Bb2 Be7 7. Ne2 h5 8. h3 Qc7

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

...d4 can close the center with a large space advantage. If every white piece lacks squares, the setup has become too slow.

08 / HW-08

Course move: 5. Ne2. White develops the king knight and prepares king safety against Black's ambitious center. Delaying b3 can be sensible when the center needs urgent attention.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. Ne2 Be6 6. O-O h5 7. c4 dxc4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black may push ...e4 or ...f4 with tempo. A slow double fianchetto can become a target if the center opens before White castles.

Answers 9-10

09 / HW-09

Course move: 5. exd4. White exchanges the invading pawn and changes the structure. Black retains a d4 wedge, but White has opened a diagonal and can attack the pawn.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. exd4 exd4 6. Nf3 Nf6 7. O-O Be7

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

The d4 pawn restricts Nc3 and may support a central outpost. Do not place a knight where an enemy pawn can simply capture it.

10 / HW-10

Course move: 5. dxe4. The central exchange releases Black's knight onto e4. White has prevented a permanent pawn wedge but must now address the active piece.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. dxe4 Nxe4 6. Nd2 Nxd2 7. Bxd2 c6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

A central knight can threaten forks on c3 or f2 depending on the position. Check its concrete attacks before making another pawn move.

Answers 11-12

11 / HW-11

Course move: 5. O-O. White abandons the strict Ne2 formation and develops quickly against Black's space. Nf3 is a practical adaptation when central pressure matters more than symmetry.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. O-O Bc5 6. Nbd2 Nge7 7. Ne4 Bb6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can consolidate with ...Nf6 and ...Be7. Further waiting can let the d4 pawn become a permanent restriction.

12 / HW-12

Course move: 6. Bb2. Black supports d5 and may expand with ...e4. White's b2 bishop puts indirect pressure on e5, but that pressure depends on the central pawn contacts.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Bb2 O-O 7. Nd2 Re8 8. Ngf3 h6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

...e4 can gain space and attack useful squares. Do not count a bishop as attacking through your own e3 pawn.

Answers 13-14

13 / HW-13

Course move: 3. Nxh4. Black attacks the g3 pawn before building a center. Nf3 develops and can capture on h4 when Black advances without support.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

3. Nxh4 e5 4. e4 Nc6 5. d3 d5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black may strike in the center while the knight sits on the rim. Do not keep chasing pawns instead of developing.

14 / HW-14

Course move: 5. h3. White restrains ...h4 by preparing to meet the pawn contact on favorable terms. This is a specific defensive decision, not a requirement to play h3 in every Hippo.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. h3 Be6 6. a3 a5 7. Nc3 Qd7

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can prepare ...g5 or castle long. A pawn on h3 can become a hook if the rest of the position is neglected.

Answers 15-16

15 / HW-15

Course move: 4. e3. Black gains kingside space while delaying development. White should look for central action and king safety rather than merely copying a pawn wall.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

4. e3 g5 5. Nc3 Be6 6. e4 d4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can play ...h5-h4 and gain attacking tempi. A passive reply may turn a premature advance into a strong attack.

16 / HW-16

Course move: 7. Bxh3. Black exchanges the g2 bishop and brings the queen toward White's already castled king. White's knight has left g1, so the queen on h3 cannot simply be captured by that knight.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7. Bxh3 Qxh3 8. e4 Nf6 9. exd5 Nxd5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

If White's knight were still on g1, ...Qxh3 would lose the queen to Nxxh3. In this line its different square makes the attack a real concern.

Answers 17-18

17 / HW-17

Course move: 6. Bb2. Black attacks the b3 structure and seeks open queenside lines. White must calculate the pawn contact before adding a routine knight move.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Bb2 a4 7. a3 axb3 8. cxb3 Bg4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

The b2 bishop and a1 rook can become targets when files open. A queenside attack may matter even if your king plans to castle short.

18 / HW-18

Course move: 5. Bd2. The bishop check interrupts the setup. Bd2 develops while blocking; the queen bishop does not have to reach b2 in every game.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. Bd2 a5 6. a3 Bc5 7. Nf3 Nc6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Moving a pawn to block without checking the resulting weaknesses may cost time. A fixed formation is no reason to choose an inferior response to check.

Answers 19-20

19 / HW-19

Course move: 6. c4. White challenges d5 with active development and a castled king. This useful departure resembles a Reti or reversed King's Indian structure more than a complete Hippo.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. c4 O-O 7. cxd5 Nxd5 8. Nc3 Be6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

If Black closes with ...d4, Nc3 may be restricted. Plan the knight route before fixing every pawn.

20 / HW-20

Course move: 7. e4. White adopts a King's Indian Attack center because Black's structure makes it useful. The b-pawn remains flexible instead of being committed automatically.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7. e4 Nc6 8. Re1 Qc7 9. c3 h6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can exchange on e4 or advance ...d4. Do not assume the e5 attack is available in every branch.

Answers 21-22

21 / HW-21

Course move: 7. d4. White uses development and king safety to justify a central claim. The d-pawn advances only after the pieces are ready to cope with exchanges.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7. d4 e4 8. b4 Re8 9. c4 h5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Advancing d4 may leave e3 weak or open lines for Black too. A central gain is not free of structural consequences.

22 / HW-22

Course move: 6. Qxd8+. The exchanges open the d-file and allow White to remove queens. Black loses castling rights, but with queens gone the main issue is piece activity and pawn targets.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Qxd8+ Kxd8 7. Ne2 Bf5 8. Nd2 Bc5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black's centralized king may become useful if the position simplifies further. A lost castling right alone does not prove an advantage.

Answers 23-24

23 / HW-23

Course move: 6. c4. White develops actively and challenges the center with c4 rather than waiting for a full double fianchetto. Black's f-pawn commitment helps define the dark-square battle.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. c4 d6 7. Nc3 Nc6 8. Rb1 a5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can build a strong kingside attack if given too much time. Do not answer every threat with a small pawn move.

24 / HW-24

Course move: 6. Ngf3. Black blocks the g2-b7 diagonal with Nc6 before putting the bishop on b7. White uses the flank development to establish a central foothold.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Ngf3 d5 7. e5 Nd7 8. d4 Ba6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Immediate ...Bb7 without a blocker would leave that bishop available to Bxb7. Check the long diagonal before assuming a normal fianchetto is safe.

Answers 25-26

25 / HW-01

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d3, e3. Black king g8; central-file pawns d5, e5, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Resolve king safety and choose c4, d4 or e4 as a central challenge. Identify which bishop will become active after the chosen break.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black has more space and can prepare ...e4 or ...d4. White's extra tempo has not prevented a central bind. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

26 / HW-03

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns f2, d3, e3, c4. Black king g8; central-file pawns d4, c5, e5, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Complete development and decide whether c4 or e4 best opens your bishops. Count the pressure on b2 after the center clears.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can advance ...d4 and restrict the b1 knight. The g7 bishop may become stronger than its white counterpart after exchanges. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 27-28

27 / HW-05

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d3, e4. Black king g8; central-file pawns e5, f5, d6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Compare e4 with c4 and develop the king knight to support that choice. Decide whether the b2 bishop has useful pressure before exchanging e-pawns.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can use ...Nc6 and ...Be6 to develop with central influence. A later ...d5 may seize the initiative if White waits too long. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

28 / HW-07

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns c2, d3, e3, f4. Black king e8; central-file pawns e4, c5, d5, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop a knight to support c4 or e4, and calculate the resulting exchanges. Consider whether a partial formation gives more active play than the complete shell.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

...d4 can close the center with a large space advantage. If every white piece lacks squares, the setup has become too slow. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 29-30

29 / HW-09

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns f2, d3. Black king g8; central-file pawns c3, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop Ne2 or Nf3 and target d4 with c3 when safe. Decide whether the queen bishop belongs on b2 or a more direct square.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

The d4 pawn restricts Nc3 and may support a central outpost. Do not place a knight where an enemy pawn can simply capture it. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

30 / HW-11

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns e2, f2, d3. Black king g8; central-file pawns e5, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Use e3 or c3 to undermine d4, and bring out the queen knight to support the chosen break.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can consolidate with ...Nf6 and ...Be7. Further waiting can let the d4 pawn become a permanent restriction. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 31-32

31 / HW-14

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d3, e3. Black king e8; central-file pawns d5, e5, f6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop quickly and consider central counterplay. If ...h4 arrives, calculate gxh4 and exchanges rather than assuming the wing is locked.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can prepare ...g5 or castle long. A pawn on h3 can become a hook if the rest of the position is neglected. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

32 / HW-16

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d3. Black king e8; central-file pawns e5, f6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Inspect checks and dark-square threats, develop with tempo if available and look for central counterplay. The king is already on g1, so the task is defending the actual shelter.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

If White's knight were still on g1, ...Qxh3 would lose the queen to Nxh3. In this line its different square makes the attack a real concern. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 33-34

33 / HW-18

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d3. Black king e8; central-file pawns d4, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Complete development and decide whether a later bishop exchange improves coordination. Keep the central pawns supported and castle when safe.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Moving a pawn to block without checking the resulting weaknesses may cost time. A fixed formation is no reason to choose an inferior response to check. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

34 / HW-20

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c3, d3, e4. Black king g8; central-file pawns c5, d5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Support e4, then assess e5 and the available knight routes. Use the KIA course for deeper study of this exact center.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can exchange on e4 or advance ...d4. Do not assume the e5 attack is available in every branch. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 35-36

35 / HW-22

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e3. Black king d8; central-file pawns e4, c6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop the knights, assess the e4 pawn and activate the king when safe. Do not keep playing for a direct king attack without queens.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black's centralized king may become useful if the position simplifies further. A lost castling right alone does not prove an advantage. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

36 / HW-24

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4, e5. Black king e8; central-file pawns c5, d5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Castle, support e4 and compare central exchanges. The position may become a KIA-style game rather than a complete Hippo.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Immediate ...Bb7 without a blocker would leave that bishop available to Bxb7. Check the long diagonal before assuming a normal fianchetto is safe. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 37-38

37 / HW-LAB-01

The finite search prefers Nf3 (-0.95 from White's perspective), compared with g4 (-1.01 from White's perspective). Develops the king knight toward e5 and d4. In the King's Gambit it also controls h4, making an immediate queen check there unattractive.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. Nf3 h6 12. d4 Bf5 13. dxe5 Nxe5 14. Nxe5 Bxe5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. g4 h6 12. Ng3 Ne7 13. Nf3 d4 14. g5 Nfd5

38 / HW-LAB-01

The finite search prefers Nxc6 (-1.15 from White's perspective), compared with Nf4 (-1.16 from White's perspective). The knight captures a knight on c6. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Nxc6 bxc6 16. Nf4 Bf5 17. Qe2 Qb7 18. O-O Qc8

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. Nf4 Bf5 16. Nxc6 bxc6 17. Qe2 Qb7 18. Bc3 Nh7

Answers 39-40

39 / HW-LAB-02

The finite search prefers dxe4 (-0.60 from White's perspective), compared with Bxf6 (-1.37 from White's perspective). The pawn captures a pawn on e4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. dxe4 dxe4 12. Nec3 Rd8 13. Nd2 Qc8 14. Qe2 Bxh3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. Bxf6 Bxf6

40 / HW-LAB-02

The finite search prefers hxg4 (-0.39 from White's perspective), compared with Qd2 (-1.24 from White's perspective). The pawn captures a bishop on g4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. hxg4 Nxg4+

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. Qd2 Bf5 16. Nb5 O-O 17. Nd6 Bxd6 18. Bxf6 Be7

Answers 41-42

41 / HW-LAB-03

The finite search prefers Nf3 (+0.68 from White's perspective), compared with b4 (+0.00 from White's perspective). Develops the king knight toward e5 and d4. In the King's Gambit it also controls h4, making an immediate queen check there unattractive.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. Nf3 Qf5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. b4 Rxh4 12. gxh4 Nf5 13. Re4 Nd6 14. Re1

42 / HW-LAB-03

The finite search prefers c3 (+1.09 from White's perspective), compared with b4 (+0.91 from White's perspective). Places the pawn on c3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. c3 Kb8 16. b4 Nd6 17. c4 Bf5 18. Ne3 Bc8

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. b4 Ncd4 16. Be3 Nxf3+ 17. Qxf3 Qxf3 18. Bxf3 g6

Answers 43-44

43 / HW-LAB-04

The finite search prefers d4 (-0.66 from White's perspective), compared with c4 (-1.17 from White's perspective). Changes central space and pawn contacts. Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension before choosing the next piece plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. d4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. c4 Nde7 12. b4 Nf5 13. b5 Ncd4 14. Nxd4 Nxd4

44 / HW-LAB-04

The finite search prefers Nfd2 (-0.38 from White's perspective), compared with Nbd2 (-0.44 from White's perspective). Places the knight on d2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Nfd2 Qxd1 16. Rxd1 Ncd4 17. Nc3 Be7 18. Rb1 h5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. Nbd2 Ncd4

Answers 45-46

45 / HW-LAB-05

The finite search prefers Rc1 (-0.08 from White's perspective), compared with Re1 (-0.08 from White's perspective). Places the rook on c1. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. Rc1

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. Re1 Nxc3 12. Bxc3 f6 13. Qa4 Rfd8 14. Nd2 Nd4

46 / HW-LAB-05

The finite search prefers Nh4 (-0.10 from White's perspective), compared with Rfe1 (-0.16 from White's perspective). Places the knight on h4. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Nh4 Bb3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. Rfe1 Nd8 16. Nh4 Bxg2 17. Kxg2 g5 18. Nf3 g4

Answers 47-48

47 / HW-LAB-06

The finite search prefers a3 (+0.10 from White's perspective), compared with a4 (+0.03 from White's perspective). Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. a3 b5 12. exd5 exd5 13. d4 c4 14. Ne5 Re8

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. a4 Rb8

48 / HW-LAB-06

The finite search prefers Nb3 (+0.18 from White's perspective), compared with a5 (+0.04 from White's perspective). Places the knight on b3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Nb3 Bb7 16. Bf4 Qc8 17. a5 a6 18. Rad1 Bf8

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. a5 Nxa5